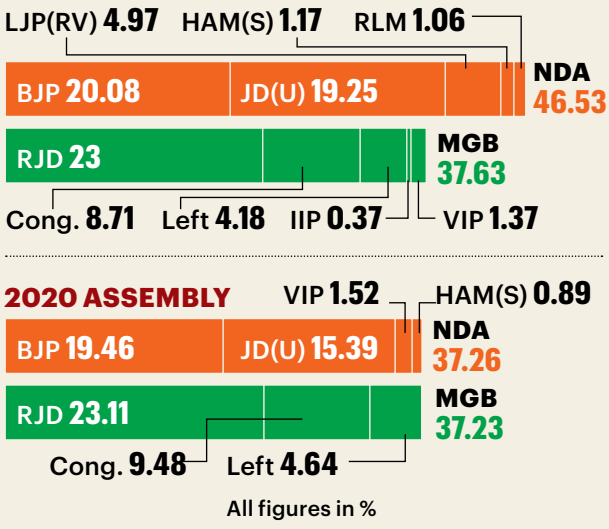
LEADING BY A MILE

The NDA's vote share rose from near-parity in 2020 to a clear lead in 2025



All figures in %

HOW THE NDA WON

Coalition engineering

Calibrated seat-sharing—helped by the LJP's return and alliances such as the HAM(S) and RLM—broadened the NDA's OBC-EBC-Dalit base, lifted JD(U)'s numbers and pushed the alliance's vote share

The women engine

The Rs 10,000 'seed money' pledge for 15.1 million women besides long-running welfare schemes (bicycles, SHGs, education, safety) made them JD(U)'s anchor demographic, driving high turnout and a 19.25% vote share

Nitish's legacy dividend

Perceptions that this could be Nitish Kumar's last major election helped consolidate support among welfare beneficiaries and long-time loyalists

Rewired caste arithmetic

By consolidating dominant castes, non-Yadav OBCs, EBCs and Mahadalits, the NDA diluted the MGB's Muslim-Yadav-centred strength. These groups, along with women voters, moved cohesively across NDA partners, enabling smooth vote transfer

The jobs edge

The 10-million-jobs pitch outmatched the RJD's promise of mass government employment

Stability over 'jungle raj'

NDA's messaging invoked memories of 1990s lawlessness under RJD rule, framing the election as a choice between order and a feared return to disorder

alone, amounts to Rs 15,100 crore. Well over half of Bihar's 48.9 million female population match the eligibility criteria, so the recipient base can extend to another 12 million. Should even the existing 15.1 million beneficiaries receive the additional Rs 2 lakh of support, the state would need a further Rs 3.02 lakh crore. Bihar's entire budget is some Rs 3.17 lakh crore, making the arithmetic unforgiving. However, according to Dr N.K. Choudhary, retired professor of economics from Patna University and a widely respected independent commentator, the state government has built in certain escape valves—making the additional Rs 2 lakh support contingent on the women's businesses being judged viable. The government may also resort to other workarounds, like approaching banks to extend soft loans backed by state guarantees.

Creating 10 million jobs in five years will require shifting industry and services to higher productivity sectors, nurturing local entrepreneurs and incentives for private sector

The other major promise the NDA made in its manifesto was of providing 10 million jobs, an undertaking meant to put an end to '*palayan*' or outmigration, an issue the Opposition raised with some success even if it did not translate into votes. According to the 2023 caste survey, over 5.3 million Biharis live outside the state. Remittances sustain 88 per cent of households, according to a report by the Mumbai-based International Institute for Population Sciences, with the mean annual remittance per migrant household Rs 48,662 in 2017.

Creating 10 million employment opportunities in five years will require an investment effort unprecedented in Bihar's history. The government has promised to attract investments worth Rs 50 lakh crore to spur growth and jobs. What it will also need is a decisive shift toward private-sector participation. Manufacturing clusters, agro-processing units, logistics hubs, tourism infrastructure and digital-service centres cannot scale without stable policies, reliable land and power supply, and an investment climate that inspires confidence among private enterprises. That calls for stronger incentives for micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs). Like for its women's employment scheme, the state will have to look for alternative sources to fund this promise as well. There are other commitments too, including higher pension payouts and increased stipends/allowances for vulnerable groups. "Bihar," says Dr